

Glossary

Baldachin

A canopy over an altar or throne.

Barrel vault

Also known as a tunnel or wagon vault; the simplest form of vault, resembling a barrel or tunnel cut in half lengthways.

Bascule

A counter-balanced structure; when one end is lowered the other is raised.

Bas-relief

A carving in which the design is raised from a flat background.

Bartizan

An overhanging, wall-mounted turret projecting from the walls of ancient fortifications.

Buttress

Masonry or brickwork that supports a wall. Flying buttresses are arches or half-arches that push back against a building's outward thrust.

Castellated

Finished with turrets and battlements.

Chinoiserie

An imitation of Chinese styles, popular in Europe during the 17th and 18th centuries.

Corbels

Structural pieces of stone, wood or metal extending from a wall, serving as brackets.

Crenellations

Battlements, especially the symmetrical, geometric forms on the top of of a parapet.

Cupola

A small, usually dome-like structure on top of a building mostly on top of a larger roof or dome, and often used to provide a lookout or to admit light and air.

Duplex

A residential building divided into two separate apartments.

Entablatures

Major elements of classical architecture; the horizontal mouldings above columns that rest on the capitals.

Gambrel roof

A roof with a small gable forming the upper part of each end.

Groin vaults

Two barrel vaults that intersect at right angles.

Gypsum mortar

also called Plaster of Paris; a mixture of plaster and sand used in the construction of many ancient structures.

Himorogi

In Shinto architecture, these are sacred spaces or altars used for worship.

Hypogeum

A term usually referring to an underground temple or tomb.

Hypostyle hall

A hall with a roof supported by columns.

Keystone

A wedge-shaped stone in the apex of an arch or vault that holds the other stones in place.

Machicolations

Openings between supporting corbels in a battlement, through which stones and other objects can be dropped.

Mansard roof

A roof with four sloping sides, each becoming steeper halfway down.

Mihrab

A semi-circular niche in the wall of a mosque, indicating the direction of Mecca for Muslims to face when praying.

Mullions

Vertical bars between the panes of glass in windows.

Obelisk

A tall, four-sided, tapering monument with a pyramid-like shape at the top.

Ogee arches

Pointed arches with s-shaped curves on both sides.

Pendentives

Triangular spaces that allow circular domes to be placed on to square or polygonal bases – or rooms – beneath.

Pilotis

Pillars, columns, or stilts that support buildings, popularized by Le Corbusier.

Pylons

Support structures for suspension bridges or highways.

Quatrefoil

An ornamental tracery design of four leaves. (Trefoil is tracery of three leaves.)

Stucco

Fine, usually white, plaster used for coating wall surfaces or moulding into architectural decorations.

Tracery

Stonework elements that support the glass in Gothic windows.

Trencadís

A type of mosaic used in Catalan modernism, created from broken ceramics.

Vihara

A Buddhist monastery, originally meaning 'a secluded place in which to walk.'

Voussoir

A wedge-shaped stone in an arch or vault, either the keystone or the springer (the bottom stone of the arch).

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Susie Hodge has an MA in the History of Art by research from Birkbeck, University of London. She is the author of over 50 books, including studies of Impressionism, Victorian art, Picasso and Monet. She is a Fellow of the Royal Society of Arts.

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